

that appears on hovering over a certain area. Adding too many invisible structures may hinder the discoverability of your product's features, so make sure frequently used features are visible structures.

3. Visible structures: 'Visible structures' refer to everything on the screen – buttons, icons, menu bars and the like. The appearance of a particular visible structure should remain consistent throughout your product or it's sure to confuse even existing customers. Also, visible structures (and even the invisible ones) should be consistent in terms of their location, for the same reason. It adds to the efficiency of the product and enhances learnability.

4. Products: If your company puts out a lot of related products, say, as part of a suite, it's imperative to maintain the general look and feel across all of them. For example, design all of the logos in this suite with the same font (unless you want to emphasise the difference in their logos, in which case, be consistent in the differences). This helps in creating and maintaining a brand image that is communicated subconsciously to your users.

5. Platforms: Today, almost every product is multi-platform. Every other website has an app, and every other app is available on every major platform. Keeping your design and user experience consistent across these platforms is essential and not easy, as every platform has its limits and advantages (desktop websites have screen space, mobile applications have portability, etc). Yet, being consistent across platforms is necessary, because it ensures easy adoption of your products.

At times, however, it's necessary to be inconsistent, when changes need to be emphasised. Nothing grabs attention like visual inconsistency, but only if it makes sense. It will make sense if the user is given the opportunity to develop an appropriate rationale, such as witnessing a behavioural inconsistency accompanying the visual inconsistency. That is, you want the user to think, "Oh! It looks different because it works differently!"

Are you maintaining the standards you've set?

The Simplicity Principle

This principle is actually complex, because it involves simplifying complex things. It isn't as simple as merely hiding the complexity, as that can ironically add to the complexity by making features less discoverable. Keeping your design as simple as possible involves walking a fine line, where you